24

CURRENT PRACTICES IN FORESKIN RESTORATION

The State of Affairs in the United States, and Results of a Survey of Restoring Men

R. Wayne Griffiths

INTRODUCTION

In November 1989, in San Francisco, Tim Hammond and I founded The National Organization of Restoring Men (NORM), a support organisation for circumcised men desiring to restore their foreskin. NORM was the first known support group of its kind in the United States, and perhaps in the world.[1]

Prior to the founding of NORM, I had already been using a simple, non-surgical method of foreskin restoration for approximately one year. Tim had also started to use this method. Realising the potential benefits to be gained from sharing and pooling information about restoration methods with as many active restorers as possible, Tim suggested that we found a support group. We pooled our resources and placed classified advertisements in two San Francisco Bay Area newspapers. The response was overwhelming. Both Tim and I received more than 200 telephone calls each within the first few months of the run of the advertisement.

1. PURPOSE AND GOALS

After listening to the concerns of our respondents, it became immediately clear that a major purpose of our support program would be to provide a safe and confidential arena in which men, without fear of ridicule, could express their desire to be intact and whole again. NORM provides a forum for men to discuss their restoration goals, to learn about restoration methods, and to discover which methods would work best for each. NORM also strives to support men in their desire to regain a sense of physical and emotional self-determination.

Male and Female Circumcision, edited by Denniston *et al.*
Kluwer Academic / Plenum Publishers, New York, 1999.

2. GOVERNING POLICIES

NORM established the following governing policies:

> Under no circumstances would NORM reveal or provide the names of participants to anyone for any purpose without the specific permission of the individual.
>
> Attendees at NORM meetings would respect the confidentiality of all other attendees. No members' names would be used when the group is discussed outside of meetings. Individuals are at liberty, however, to share information (their own name and address) with others at their own discretion.
>
> No dues would be charged. Operating expenses would be met entirely from voluntary member donations.
>
> The agenda for each scheduled meeting would be determined by a consensus of those who regularly attended meetings.
>
> NORM would have no elected officers.
>
> Leadership for each participating group would be voluntary.
>
> The founders would be responsible for ensuring that these guidelines were respected.

Most of the men who contacted us were very concerned about issues of privacy and modesty. Because many of the men who attended NORM meetings felt that they had been deeply wounded by having been circumcised, women were not to be invited to attend the regular meetings. Many men who contacted us were so sensitive about revealing to other men the emotional pain they felt, that they chose not to participate in or even attend meetings. After attending their first meeting, however, a significant number of men expressed to me their great relief and joy at realising that there are others who feel as they do about their circumcision. They were comforted to learn that both physical and emotional recovery is possible.

3. MEETINGS

The first meeting was held on 5 February 1990 at Tim Hammond's home in San Francisco, with twelve men in attendance. Subsequent monthly meetings were held at either my home or Tim's. Attendance at each meeting ranged between ten and twenty men. Once a year, NORM organises an open meeting with guest speakers, to which members of the public (male and female), are invited. Speakers have included: Marilyn Milos, Tim Hammond, Jim Bigelow, Richard Steiner (who has had a full scrotal graft), Drew Okun, Richard M. (who both had a surgical foreskin tuck), and Dr. Ira Sharlip, who performed these surgeries. As many as sixty people have attended these meetings.

The regular attendance at monthly meetings has grown so large that NORM now rents a hall in a church in San Francisco for meetings. Group meetings, which last about two hours, begin with introductions. Then a review of current news and events in the foreskin restoration movement follows. The final portion of the meeting is devoted to group discussion in which attendees share details of their progress or ask for guidance on taping and stretching methods.

During the Second International Symposium on Circumcision (held in San Francisco, April 30 to May 3, 1991), Dr. Jim Bigelow and I gave a presentation and held a seminar on foreskin restoration. We presented a history of foreskin restoration through the ages, and we showed slides of the results of restorations by either using stretching or surgical techniques. A similar workshop was presented at the Third International Symposium on Circumcision (held from 22–25 May 1994, at the University of Maryland).

In the Spring of 1992, NORM received a tremendous number of inquiries following the publication of the first edition of Dr. Bigelow's book *The Joy of Uncircumcising!*[2] The second edition was published in late 1994,[3] and a third printing was made available in January 1998.[4]

4. MEDIA COVERAGE

Media coverage about foreskin restoration, which began as early as the Spring of 1986, has been phenomenal. Foreskin restoration has been the subject of newspaper articles, medical journal articles, television broadcasts and radio talk shows. The *Tucson Citizen*, on 10 June 1991, published Dan Sorensen's short article on restoration in addition to his longer article, "Circumcision: Is it ritual mutilation or a medical necessity?"[5–6] On 8 October 1991, the *San Jose Mercury News* published Michael Oricchio's feature article on the subject.[7] NORM was overwhelmed by the number of telephone inquiries following publication of both these articles. On 17 October 1991, a daily programme on a CBS affiliate in San Francisco, "People Are Talking," interviewed spokesmen for NORM.[8] Feature stories followed on such television programmes as the *Morton Downey Jr. Show* in Chicago,[9] and *Comedy Central*.[10] The *Comedy Central* feature on NORM was repeated early in 1998. Many radio programmes have featured stories on NORM and foreskin restoration. In March 1998, radio station KSCO in Santa Cruz, California broadcast a two-hour programme on circumcision and restoration, featuring interviews with Dr. George Denniston and me. Each of these programmes has generated a continuous flow of inquiries

While restoration is a simple, non-invasive, straightforward process, many people have difficulty dealing with this subject. Editors often edit out information on restoration in articles on circumcision. This was the case in May 1998, when *U.S. News and World Report* published an article on the growing trend away from routine circumcision in the United States.[11] The editor deleted information on restoration before the article went to press. The writer of the article, Sara Lowen, wrote to tell me that she was disappointed that the information on restoration had been deleted from her article.

Additional articles on restoration have appeared in the September/October 1994 issue of the *Journal of Sexual Medicine*,[12] *COLORS*,[13] *MAXIM*,[14] and other men's magazines. Every article, whether positive or not, brings calls and letters requesting information. Even articles or broadcasts that make light of restoration result in inquiries from men who see beyond the denial and biases of some reporters or writers.

Since its inception, NORM has received inquiries from around the world. This demonstrates that this type of support is indeed timely and necessary. There are now about 20 NORM chapters around the world. A significant percentage of requests for information on foreskin restoration comes from married men and from fathers who protected their sons from circumcision.

5. SURVEY RESULTS

Thanks to its large membership, NORM has had the opportunity to conduct an anonymous survey of its members. The results of a survey of 240 self-selected circumcised males is presented here.

The average age of respondents was 49 (range 24 to 81). In terms of demographics, of these men, 96% identified themselves as Caucasians, and 91% identified themselves

as Christians. 74% were circumcised at birth; 4% were circumcised from infancy to 6 years; 4% were circumcised from 6–12 years; 7% were circumcised from 13–19 years; 5% were circumcised from 20–29 years; and 3% were circumcised after the age of 30.

The circumcision status of the fathers of the respondents was: 38% circumcised; 46% intact; 15% status unknown. The circumcision status of male siblings was: 51% circumcised; 10% intact; and 14% status unknown.

5.1. Males Circumcised in Infancy

Respondents were asked "If you were circumcised in infancy, at what age did you realise you were circumcised?" The average age of discovery was 10 years old (range 1–36 years).

The reasons given for their circumcision were: Hygiene 38%; Phimosis 3%; Religion 9%; Family 5%; Tradition 10%; None at all 27%; Other 6%; Prevent Masturbation 1%; Prevent Bed-wetting 0%; To look like others 15%.

The person who gave the reasons for circumcision was: Mother 35%; Father 17%; Doctor 10%; Counsellor 0%; Religious Official 0%; Other 3%.

When asked whether they, since becoming an adult, had ever spoken to their parents about their circumcision, 35% responded positively, and 59% responded negatively.

When asked, which parent was more pro-circumcision. The following responses were recorded:

Mother 20%; Father 10%; Both 14%; Do not know 53%.

The parent who made the final decision was: Mother 16%; Father 9%; Both 15%; Don't know 58%.

Respondents were asked whether they had talked to anyone else regarding their concerns about circumcision or restoration. Regarding circumcision, respondents gave the following answers: Parents 16%; Friends 35%; Spouse/Partner 25%; Siblings 10%; Other 14%. For restoration, the responses were: Parents 4%; Friends 38%; Spouse/Partner 31%; Siblings 6%; Other 21%.

Respondents were asked whether they felt that circumcision had affected masturbation? 63% responded positively and 37% responded negatively.

The written explanations included such comments as: "Less sensitive;" "Need lubrication;" "Less pleasurable;" "More difficult;" "Always thinking about foreskins;" "The major dimension is now missing from orgasm;" "Need more manipulation;" "The shaft too tight;" "The penis gets dry and sore;" "The scar is too ugly to look at;" "Pain and taut skin;" "Irritation;" "More friction;" "Damage;" "Adhesions;" "Psychologically and physically damaged;" "Can't rub dry glans;" "Painful, tearing and bleeding;" "Couldn't figure out how to do it;" "Prolonged with inability to climax;" "Delayed ejaculation;" "Not enough skin;" "Desired to know what it would be like with a foreskin;" "Need more stimulation;" "Abrasions, post swelling;" "Soreness and numbness."

5.2. Males Circumcised in Adolescence

Of those that responded that they were circumcised as youths, only 41% were circumcised with their consent. 48% were not given any warning that they were to be circumcised. 59% were circumcised without their consent, and 57% were circumcised without having been given an explanation of what was happening to them prior to the surgery. Only 78% in this group had received general anaesthesia.

The most frequently cited reasons for circumcision in this group were: Hygiene 39%; Phimosis 30%; None at all 17%; Prevent Masturbation 15%; Other 7%; To look like others 7%; Tradition 5%; Religion 2%; Family 2%; Prevent Bed-wetting 2%; Other 1%.

The feelings of the youths after the surgery ranged from "unhappy" (23%), Anger/Fear (20%) to "Rage" (20%).

When asked whether the loss of the foreskin affected masturbation, 66% responded affirmatively. The explanations for why masturbation was different following the loss of the foreskin included such comments as: "Need foreskin to glide;" "Had to develop/learn a whole new technique;" "Loss of sensation;" "Need lubricants;" "Less pleasurable;" "Decreased sensitivity;" "So tight it gets sore after masturbation;" "With a foreskin it was a lot more pleasurable;" "Skin doesn't slide back and forth over the head anymore;" "A portion of the nerves is gone;" "Less sensitive, dry glans;" "Loss of feeling;" "Knowing that it didn't have to be done;" "No foreskin pleasures."

5.3. Males Circumcised as Adults

Of those men circumcised as adults, 53% said that it affected their sexual activity. There was a range of explanatory responses from "now sorry I had it done" to "less pleasure."

Of the respondents in this group, 93% reported that they had never used artificial lubricants for masturbation before circumcision. Following circumcision, 45% responded that they now had to use artificial lubricants for masturbation.

The written explanations for how circumcision had affected the sexual activity of men circumcised as adults included such comments as: "Harder now to get/keep erection;" "The penis gets sore;" "Less sensitive;" "Missing massaging action of the foreskin;" "Need lubrication;" "Effort to get to ejaculation;" "Less satisfying" "Delayed orgasm;" "Initially less sensitive, now very little feeling in glans;" "Pain along the scar;" "Friction;" "Less pleasure;" "Less enjoyable;" "Something taken from me."

5.4. General Attitudes about Being Circumcised

Respondents were asked whether they had ever felt embarrassed, or self-conscious about being circumcised. 43% replied affirmatively, and 57% replied negatively. In a society where 80 to 90% of adult males are circumcised, these would be the expected responses.

Written explanations for why circumcised males felt self-conscious included such comments as: "Self-conscious among intact guys;" "Feel crippled;" "Feel exposed;" "As a child I expected my foreskin to grow back during puberty;" "Missing some joy;" "All class mates were told;" "Botched job;" "Altered, not whole;" "Disconnected from Mexican heritage;" "Natural penis looks better;" "Hated being cut;" "Less than enough cock;" "People call me donkey dick behind my back;" "Felt cheated;" "Scarred, skin tags;" "Females prefer natural men;" "Didn't want to be seen;" "Curious in Germany;" "The doctor slipped up and had to have skin graft;" "Scars;" "Obvious prominent scar;" "Rejection;" "Embarrassed;" "Circumcision was done wrong;" "Looks funny;" "Felt incomplete;" "Feel mutilated;" "Hair all the way up the shaft;" "Rights violated;" "It's unnatural;" "Left with scars and skin tags and bridges."

Respondents were also asked to answer specific questions about their feelings about their circumcision. 21% felt inferior; 19% felt less masculine; 21% felt less

attractive; 7% felt that they were the object of ridicule; 19% felt self-conscious; and 13% felt embarrassed.

The age at which they realised that not all males were circumcised fell into the following ranges: 1–5 years, 14%; 6–12 years, 56%; 13–19 years, 21%; 20–29 years, 5%; after the age of 30, 2%.

At the time they discovered that they were circumcised and that most other males were intact, respondents reported feeling: Indifferent, 38%; mild regret, 24%; unhappy, 24%; anger, 7%; rage, 7%.

The feelings expressed towards intact males were: curiosity, 30%; envy, 24%; admiration, 18%; loss 16%; anger 7%; neutral 3%; disdain, 2%.

Of the respondents, 90% were envious of intact males. Much of this envy was related to curiosity and speculation about what life might have been like had their bodily integrity been preserved.

5.5. Men Restoring

Men learned about restoration from a wide range of sources. When asked if they felt different about themselves because of their restoration, 83% responded positively. Of the few (34) that consulted a physician, 62% were either ridiculed or treated with indifference, and 17% were told to get psychological help. Most men who are restoring felt better about themselves both psychologically and physically.

The written responses given for why respondents felt better about themselves after foreskin restoration included such comments as: "Less exposed;" "Reclaiming body control;" "Defiance of society;" "More glans sensitivity;" "More masculine;" "Confident;" "More sexual, more physically comfortable, healing;" "More like God intended;" "More complete;" "More virile;" "Empowered;" "Greater self-control;" "Starting to feel better sexually;" "Becoming whole;" "Cleared up embarrassing irritation;" "Happier;" "Feeling healed;" "Natural appearance;" "More sexual and natural;" "Positive-feel and appearance;" "Got back what they took;" "Greater sense of loss;" "Whole again;" "Sex is better;" "Glans feels cozy;" "Self-assured;" "Much more sensitive;" "Repairing damaged self;" "Define my own masculinity and sexuality;" "Sexuality gradually returning;" "Can't articulate;" "WOW!" "Burden lifted;" "Don't need permission;" "Sense of excitement;" "Secure in my own masculinity;" "Like God made me;" "Can do something against circumcision;" "Proud of my natural penis;" "More erotic-aesthetically pleased;" "Feel more attractive and sexy;" "Righting a wrong;" "Destiny;" "A whole lot better and feels great" "Better sensation;" "Regaining a part of myself;" "More like I should have been;" "More accepted;" "More confident;" "Complete and more self-esteem;" "Took back control;" "Confidence;" "More functional;" "Much better;" "Feel more normal;" "Feels great to help oneself;" "Regaining dignity;" "More hopeful;" "Works the way it should;" "Enjoy sex play more;" "The more I have the better I feel about my penis;" "Resembles original and have more penis;" "More fun."

6. RESTORATION PROCESS

Members of NORM are in various stages of restoration. Frequently heard comments are: "How do I get started?" or "I have had great success and feel my restoration is complete." NORM advocates the use of the gentle stretching methods to achieve

restoration. Most men would prefer to have an instantaneous restoration but unfortunately, this is not possible. Tissue expansion is a slow process, but it is the least intrusive and results in a permanent and cosmetically satisfying restoration. NORM is aware of the various surgical techniques for foreskin restoration and is aware of doctors willing to perform such surgeries. These surgeries, however, are usually very expensive and have often resulted in failure. Success with restoration through gentle stretching is limited only by the degree of one's commitment and persistence. Non-surgical foreskin restoration is effective, painless, and permanent. Dr. Donald Greer, a pioneer in surgical restoration, recently said that, if a man can stretch, he should do it because it is the least intrusive technique and gives the best results.[15]

There are, at present, four commercial devices available for use in foreskin restoration: FOREBALLS (tandem bearings); TUGGER/PUD (cylinder with a cup); BUD (cylinder with a detachable cup); and Second Skin Cones (weighted silicone cones). All of these devices are weighted and work by applying, with the aid of gravity, continuous and moderate traction to the skin. NORM makes a point of objective review and reserves recommendation of any device. Since there are advantages and disadvantages to each device, we advise men to choose an existing device or make one suited to their own needs. An elastic strapping system is no longer commercially available, but is simple to make. For many men, the restoration process is a "do it yourself" project. Most types of devices can be made at home following the guidelines in *The Joy of Uncircumcising!* The above mentioned devices are held in place with surgical adhesive tape. While many types of surgical tapes are suitable for restoration, one especially useful product is Tegaderm, a type of tape that has the advantage of allowing the skin to stretch under it.

Dr. Jon Franks of San Francisco has recently devised a "Theraderm System" of restoration that employs this product.

7. FUTURE ROLE OF NORM

In December 1992, NORM's founders decided to separate the responsibilities of activism and support. Tim Hammond founded NOHARMM (National Organization to Halt the Abuse and Routine Mutilation of Males) as an activist organisation, leaving NORM to deal exclusively with restoration support. NOHARMM has been very successful in raising public awareness about the long-term harm of circumcision. NOHARMM has also had an impact on the medical establishment and is regularly mentioned in medical journal articles dealing with circumcision.

Today, there is a strong network of organisations serving all facets of this great campaign to protect children from genital cutting and help males who have been harmed by it. Increasing numbers of men are feeling empowered to speak out, to educate others about the long-term consequences of circumcision, and to spread the information that it is possible to recover from circumcision, physically, and emotionally.

At this time, over ten thousand copies of *The Joy of Uncircumcising!* have been sold. I have personally received more than five thousand pieces of correspondence requesting information or asking questions about restoration. The Internet has made information on restoration available to even more people through World Wide Web sites and internet discussion groups.

NORM has its own internet website.[16] Although this represents a great advance in getting information to a greater number of men, it will be five to ten years more

before even half the people in the United States have computers or Internet access. The postal service and the telephone are and will remain the major means of contact during this period. Personal contact with groups or individuals is one of the main purposes of NORM. The on-line connection is not personal or confidential enough to provide men with a safe environment in which to express their feelings about their circumcision or to receive support from others.

The results of NORM's survey, as well as the results of a similar poll conducted by NOHARMM,[17] indicate that circumcised men in the United States are growing aware of what circumcision has done to them. NORM is confident that its continued programme of educational outreach will not only spare baby boys from sexual mutilation, but will bring new hope to men of all ages who have been harmed by circumcision. Men will become aware of the fact that they can restore their bodies and regain a sense of wholeness and physical integrity.

REFERENCES

1. A provisional name for the organisation was RECAP (the acronym for "RECover A Penis), In 1993, the name of the organisation was officially registered as NORM.
2. Bigelow J. *The Joy of Uncircumcising!* Aptos: Hourglass Publishing Co. 1992.
3. Bigelow J. *The Joy of Uncircumcising!* 2nd ed. Aptos: Hourglass Publishing Co. 1994.
4. Bigelow J. *The Joy of Uncircumcising!* 2nd ed. Aptos: Hourglass Publishing Co. 1994, 1998.
5. Sorenson D. The Pro and Cons of Circumcision. Is it ritual mutilation or a medical necessity? *Tucson Citizen* (June 10, 1991):1B, 3B.
6. Sorenson D. Foreskin restoration is alternative for men willing to test techniques. *Tucson Citizen* (June 10, 1991):3B.
7. Oricchio M. The unkindest cut of all? These men think so. *San Jose Mercury News* (Living Section). (Tuesday, October 8, 1991):1D, 10D.
8. *People are Talking*. KPIX. Ann Fraser and Ross McGowan, hosts. (October 17, 1991). San Francisco, California.
9. Morton Downey Jr. Show. (Show No. 9547). To Cut or Not to Cut. Morton Downey, Jr, host. (March 30, 1995). Chicago, IL.
10. Healing the Scars of Circumcision. The Daily Show. Comedy Central, (Comedy Central, COM), Janeane Garofalo, Beth Littleford, and Craig Kilborn, hosts. (First shown on April, 28, 1997, repeated about every six months). New York, NY.
11. Lowen SJ. Rethinking a custom: circumcision is no longer an automatic decision for parents. *U.S. News and World Report* 1998;124(23):66. (June 15, 1998).
12. Warren JP, Bigelow J. The case against circumcision. *Journal of Sexual Medicine* 1994;21(5):6–8.
13. Ridgeway T, ed. Transformation, 12 steps to a new you, un-circumcising devices. *Colors*, issue No. 18 (December 1996–January 1997):29, 93–95.
14. Gillie O. A cut below, off with his foreskin? *Maxim*, issue 12 (April 1996):62–5.
15. Personal correspondence. 1996.
16. http://www.norm.org/
17. NOHARMM. *Awakenings: A Preliminary Poll of Circumcised Men*. San Francisco: National Organisation to Halt the Abuse and Routine Mutilation of Males. 1994.